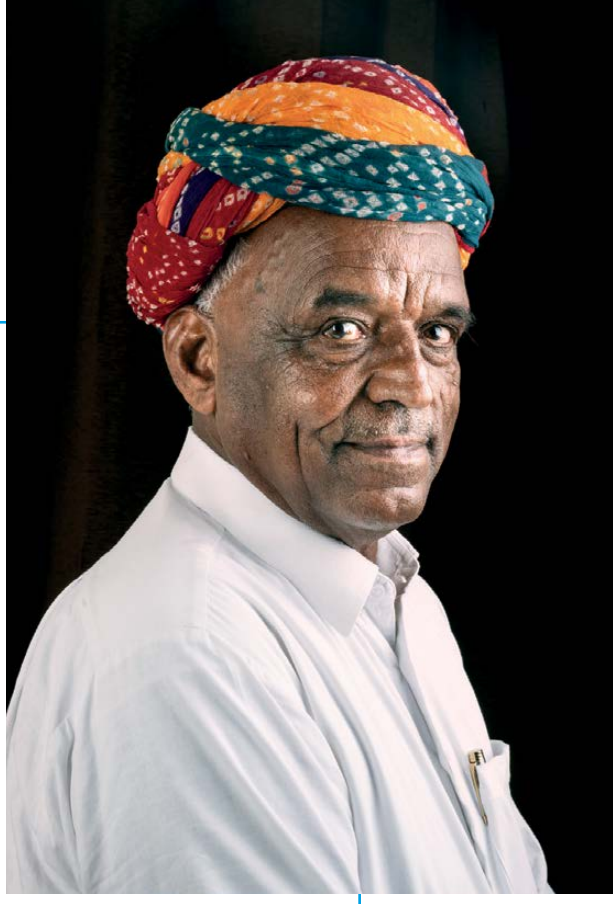


HARDIK CHHABRA

AMRA RAM, *68* ▶

| CPI (M) | *Sikar, Rajasthan*

This grassroots Marxist is a better exemplar of the never-say-die spirit than the parable of King Bruce and the spider. It's on his eighth attempt that he has entered Parliament, defeating two-time BJP MP Sumedhanand Saraswati at that. He first contested 28 years ago! Still living the simple Shekhawati life he was born into, this BSc-BEd-MCom holder quit his government teacher's job for politics, was an elected sarpanch from 1983-93 and a four-time MLA, but never lost that earth connection, including when he camped for 11 months with protesting farmers on the Delhi borders in 2021-22.



▲ DARSHAN SINGH CHAUDHARY, *48*

| BJP | *Hoshangabad, MP*

Don't be misled by his four Master's degrees—in Economics, History, Philosophy and English. The bachelor-agriculturist grew up organically on RSS farms, possesses only a mobike, leans towards cow-based natural farming, and has a yen for agitations, with 11 prison logs to show for it. The state Kisan Morcha chief hasn't entirely quit his engagement with his first vocation, teaching, either. On both counts, he'll have plenty to be agitated over in Parliament.



▲ PRADEEP PUROHIT, *58*

| BJP | *Bargarh, Odisha*

The man with a permanent red tilak on his forehead started as a green activist–leading the 'BALCO Hatao' agitation of the 1980s, one of India's oldest environmental movements, where tribals laid a four-year protective shield around the verdant Gandhamardan Hill. Purohit's potential has been mined well, though: after stints as an MLA and state Kisan Morcha chief, Purohit has now taken the Ram rath all the way to Delhi, with Odisha's highest victory margin in 2024.



▲ RAJARAM SINGH, *66*

| CPI(ML) | *Karakat, Bihar*

It was billed as a fight between polyvalent politician Upendra Kushwaha and Bhojpuri actor-singer Pawan Singh. But any labourer at the chai shops in Karakat could have told you that this one was for Rajaram. The son of a marginal Kushwaha farmer, and a BTech who chose not to pursue a career in engineering, the left-winger spent his life ploughing himself back into the soil. Another sentinel from the farmer siege on Delhi's borders, Rajaram now has the chance to cultivate the debate in the Hall of the People.

-Prashant Srivastava, Rohit Parihar, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Rahul Noronha and Amitabh Srivastava